

All about analogies

An analogy is a logical presentation of two different ideas which lead on to a conclusion.

Please see the following example:

Step 1: State your challenge

A timber yard owner stated "In what ways might I sell more timber?"

Step 2: Choose a keyword or phrase in the challenge

He chose "sell".

Step 3: Choose a parallel or distant field

The greater the distance that the parallel is from your challenge, the greater your chance of producing new thoughts and ideas. A business analogy for a business challenge is too close – analogies from television or cookery might be more likely to stimulate creative thought.

The field the timber yard owner selected was computers.

Step 4: List the images that you associate with your chosen field, then choose one or more particularly rich ones

Listing images will allow you to describe the analogy in as much detail as possible.

Among the images evoked by the computer field are: science, multiple uses, user-friendly, hardware, software, add-ons, computer-aided design, schools, business use and recreational use.

Step 5: Look for similarities and connections between the two components of your analogy

Looking for connections between the two fields should be thought of as a fun challenge, it's not supposed to be a strenuous task – it's just something to get you thinking more creatively.

The timber yard owner looked at a number of connections between the images and his challenge of selling more timber, ultimately discarding most of them. The final images he focused on were: computer-aided design (CAD), computer add-ons and recreational uses.

Once he thought about this, he realised he could use CAD to design timber decking for people's gardens, as well as provide a computer-based system in the timber yard so that salespeople can design decking to customer specifications. This would help the timber yard owner to sell more timber.